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Irfan Pathan

It was never going to be straightforward, and we were realistic about that from the outset. When I took over as the mentor of the Jammu and Kashmir team in 2018, Milap Mewada (head coach at the time) and I knew that the biggest challenge was not just technical or tactical — it was cultural.

So we made one principle absolutely clear: we were building a Jammu and Kashmir team. Not a Jammu team. Not a Kashmir team. Every time we spoke — in meetings, dressing rooms or in public — we were deliberate with that phrase.

Language shapes thought, and thought shapes culture.

The divide was subtle but visible. Players from Jammu had a certain approach to the game — their body language, communication and even on-field intensity had their own flavour. Players from Kashmir had a slightly different rhythm and temperament. Neither was right nor wrong. But if they were to succeed at the highest level, they had to move in one direction. That alignment, emotionally and professionally, became our central project.

My approach was simple: the mindset had to change.

One thing I noticed early on was that some players were comfortable scoring runs in the second innings. In the Ranji Trophy league stage, most matches do not produce outright results because it is a four-day game. The knockouts are different, but during the league phase, players sometimes become comfortable with scoring runs in the second innings.

For me, those runs did not carry the kind of value I was looking for.

What I wanted was impact. I wanted everyone to contribute in a way that added value to the team. That meant changing the mindset.

I still remember one of the first training days. I had asked everyone to report at 10 am. Some players arrived at 9:55, while others walked in at 10:05. The warm-up started around 10:15. We went through the practice session as planned, but after it ended, I gathered everyone together.

I told them very clearly that from the next day onwards, anyone arriving late would not be part of the practice session.

The next day, the same thing happened. One of the assistant coaches and a few players were late. They did not train that day. They simply stood and watched the rest of the team practise.

I wanted to instil discipline from the start. In cricket, success often

comes down to small things: discipline, preparation and mindset.

We also changed the way we trained. We introduced several drills involving both skill and fitness. When players were batting in the nets, they usually batted for about half an hour. But instead of just facing deliveries, they had to run after every third ball.

That meant their fitness was constantly being tested. At the same time, it forced them to remain mentally switched on, even when at the non-striker's end. It helped simulate match situations.

Gradually, the focus shifted towards a team-first mentality.

It was no longer about chasing personal milestones. Even if someone did not score a hundred, it was fine. What mattered was whether the player was making an impact for the team. For me, the most important runs are the ones scored in the first innings. That is where you set up the game and give your team the best chance of pushing for a result.

These changes did not happen overnight. It took time for everyone to adjust, but eventually the players understood what we were trying to build.

Once that mindset began to shift, we started to see results.

I genuinely enjoyed that challenge. It forced us to think beyond drills and